

murder in 744 of the caliph al-Walid, a member of the Umayyad family that had ruled from Damascus since 661, civil war broke out, ending only when the Abbasid dynasty came to power in 750. The Abbasids spent their first decade pacifying the empire, with the help of troops from Khurasan in northeastern Iran. These troops, a mixture of Arab-speakers, Persians, and central Asians, had been among the Abbasids' principal backers and had provided them with a power base independent of the Arab tribes based in northern Arabia, Syria, and Iraq who had supported the Umayyads.

It was in part to provide land for his Khurasani soldiers that al-Mansur, the second Abbasid caliph, established the city of Baghdad in 762. He chose the site for its mild climate and its location on the trade routes between Persia, Arabia, and the Mediterranean. It was also just 20 miles to the southeast of the Persian royal seat at Ctesiphon, which it soon eclipsed, enabling the new dynasty to portray themselves as masters of a culture that stretched back to Cyrus the Great in the 6th century BCE. The heart of the new capital was a mile-wide, circular enclosure in which sat the caliphal palace and main government offices.

Search for knowledge

The Abbasids laid claim not only to their predecessors' political heritage, but also to

their cultural and scientific achievements. Although the Umayyad Empire had included ancient seats of Greek learning such as Alexandria in Egypt, under their rule there had been little sponsorship of scientific endeavor. This changed under the Abbasids, who spent their time consolidating Islamic rule rather than on campaigns of conquest. They sponsored scholars to explore knowledge gained from foreign works, rather than relying solely on the guidance found in the Quran and the *hadiths* (the sayings of the Prophet Muhammad).

The earliest advances were made in medicine. During the mid- to late 6th century, a philosophical school at Gundeshapur in south-western Iran became a center of medical scholarship. It was staffed mainly by Christians from the Nestorian sect, which had been persecuted in the Byzantine Empire. In 765, al-Mansur is said to have summoned staff member Jurjis ibn Jibril ibn Bukhtishu to Baghdad to diagnose a stomach complaint. So pleased was the caliph with his treatment that he prevailed upon Jurjis to stay on as his personal physician, and for eight generations until the mid-11th century, members of the Bukhtishu family occupied the position at the Baghdad court, bringing with them knowledge of Greek and Hellenistic texts and medical practices. In 800, Caliph Harun al-Rashid asked Jibril »

Harun al-Rashid



Harun (763–809) succeeded as caliph in 783 after the mysterious death of his older brother al-Hadi, who had reigned for just one year. For the first 20 years of his reign,

the Barmecide family, who helped strengthen a powerful central administration, dominated court. Under Harun's rule, Baghdad became the most powerful city in the Islamic world, and flourished as a center of knowledge, culture, invention, and trade. Even so, for almost two decades Harun based himself at Raqqa, closer to the frontiers of the Byzantine Empire, against which he launched a raid in 806, personally commanding an army of many thousands. Harun's

gift of an elephant to Charlemagne in 802 was part of a series of diplomatic exchanges with the Frankish court that were intended to put further pressure on the Byzantines.

Harun's House of Wisdom, a translation bureau, library, and academy for scholars and intellectuals from across the empire, contributed to his nickname al-Rashid ("the Just"). He died in 809 while on an expedition to Khurasan in the northeast of Iran.